

The environmental and economical impact of "AI"

Posted by u/CuteCreatorgal • 0 points • 9 comments

[**How AI is causing people to abandon neighbourhoods**](<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=DIPMSDXNsV8>)

[**Environmental impact of AI Data Centres**](<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=t-8TDOFqkQA>)

Above are links to informative journalistic documentaries into how Data Centers and have been destroying people's lives/communities and resulting them having to abandon their neighbourhoods, as well as the economical and environmental impact of these data centres (Which "AI" relies on to function)*

I often see arguments centered around surface level issues, which often cover unethical data scraping, rendering artists "obsolete", and replacing human employment with automation.

Although these discussions are important, I believe a lot of people who are obsessively Pro "AI" have trouble with empathy toward their fellow humans, and have a "Keep up or perish" mindset, which at a fundamental level is anti-social and does not help keep a society healthy. Helping people to understand that "AI" affects everybody negatively (including themselves) may help some people view the bloated tech from a different perspective.

The most pressing problems that "AI" imposes on us, are the data centers that have been/are continuing to be built.

[**These centers have been directly increasing your electricity and water bills**]

(<https://www.bloomberg.com/graphics/2025-ai-data-centers-electricity-prices/>), with electricity prices rising rapidly, recently [**outpacing inflation**](<https://www.eia.gov/todayinenergy/detail.php?id=63064>). *How does this happen?* [Tech giants have been placing bids on annual power grid auctions to secure capacity for their data centers] (<https://www.csis.org/analysis/electricity-supply-bottleneck-us-ai-dominance>), which means you get to pay for the increased prices as they are competing directly with you for land and water and energy supply.

For those of you who DO care about other humans, here is how it affects their neighbourhoods and environment; After the construction of data centers, residential neighborhoods situated nearby are being directly impacted. These residents have no say over the construction or location, and they plan to pop up incrementally. Residents have documented resorting to relying on ear plugs to sleep at night due to severe noise & light pollution, [water supply contamination into households, low water pressure (almost zero water coming into households) resulting in people abandoning neighbourhoods](<https://www.instagram.com/reel/DMfpOGlutse/?igsh=MnBqajU1MXBtMXdq>). (*This is also documented in the linked documentaries above.)*

^ There is no definitive public directory of data centers, no official map, no single regulator to ask or government agency to foil. This means that it's currently almost impossible to get records because these companies don't want to disclose all of their information.

Drought Issues; In places of drought and water stress such as Phoenix and Arizona, the situation is concerning. Some centers are drilling into the ground to use groundwater. other centers are drawing most of their water from the Colorado River. The high water demand is intensifying the water crisis in the American Southwest, which is facing one of its worst droughts in over a millennium.

^ The Colorado River makes its way south from the Rocky Mountains. It's precious water is siphoned off for agriculture industry and housing. Since 2000, river flow has shrunk by 20% so by the time it reaches Arizona, every drop counts. [These maps show how extreme drought has gripped the state since 2000]

(<https://www.azwater.gov/drought/drought-status>)

\^ [A federal report](<https://escholarship.org/uc/item/32d6m0d1#page=50>) *estimated that in 2023, indirect water consumption footprint (from electricity use) of data centers in the United States was roughly 211 billion gallons. Given that 176 terawatt-hours (TWh) of electricity were consumed by data centers in 2023, the centers indirect water consumption can be estimated at 1.2 gallons per kWh on average nationally in 2023.*

****Tax breaks;**** Massive corporations are benefitting from various taxes in different states for their data centers. States are offering tax incentive programs to data centers, such as zero tax on building materials, machinery or equipment & Preferential rates on water/electricity.

[At least 10 states already lose more than \$100 million per year in tax revenue to data centers. Of the 32 states with tax incentives to data centers, 12 fail to disclose even aggregate revenue losses](<https://goodjobsfirst.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/04/Cloudy-with-a-Loss-of-Spending-Control-How-Data-Centers-Are-Endangering-State-Budgets.pdf>)

While these over bloated tech companies get massive tax breaks, your schools get cuts, your healthcare gets cuts, your social services gets cuts. Sen. Erin Maye Quade [****highlights this corruption****](<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xcfV-VV3rvw>) as Minnesota publishes a tax expenditure report showing how much money you *don't* collect because of tax exemptions — money that could be going to schools, nursing homes, disability services, and more.

\^ “All politicians and corporations want to talk about are the benefits, while ignoring or downplaying the costs of development subsidies. Let the companies compete on quality and price, not on how much they can extract from taxpayers and distort economic development and land use.” Greg LeRoy

****I don't want to add on much more as this post is already large enough as it is, I hope the issues above help some of us understand the real threats surrounding "AI".****

****It's not you vs me, It's billionaire corporations vs the general population.****

Comments

u/Aggravating-Play5388 • 1 points • 2025-11-28 20:19 UTC

This is a really solid post – I'm glad you're zooming in on the material and fiscal side of AI instead of just “it'll take our jobs.”

A few things I'd underline from the research side:

1. ****Training vs inference**** The biggest single spikes are from *training* frontier models (multi-week runs on tens of thousands of GPUs). Some academic estimates put a single run in the ballpark of the lifetime emissions of hundreds of cars. Inference (everyday use of ChatGPT/Copilot, etc.) is much smaller per prompt, but the volume of requests makes it non-trivial at scale. It's not “one prompt = a kettle,” but it's absolutely not free once you multiply by billions.
2. ****Water + siting really matter**** The USGS-style estimates you reference (hundreds of billions of gallons indirectly tied to data centers, ~1.2 gal/kWh) match what I've seen. The catch: putting those facilities in water-stressed regions means the same gallon has a much higher ecological and social cost. On top of that, “water-positive” marketing often ignores *where* they're replenishing versus *where* they're actually drawing down.
3. ****Tax breaks are part of the harm**** The subsidy race between states (sales-tax exemptions on equipment, cut-rate water/power) is basically a transfer from schools, health, and local services to a few hyperscalers. Even if you thought the tech was net-good, the way it's financed and sited is pretty hard to justify.
4. ****It's not just AI, but AI amplifies an ugly baseline**** Data centers were already extractive; AI just adds a huge new demand layer on top. So the “but streaming / crypto are bad too” defense misses that AI is accelerating an already bad pattern rather than

swapping anything out.

On the “what can anyone do?” side, I agree this is mostly structural, but there are some levers: use local/on-device models where possible, prefer text over image/video generation when you can, and push vendors and regulators for basic transparency on locations, water sources, and real energy mix (not just RECs).

Bias check: I co-founded a small AI chat platform (Earthly Insight) that’s text-first, avoids image generation, and donates a fixed share of revenue to rewilding projects. I don’t see that as “green AI” or a real offset – more like “if this stuff is going to exist anyway, it should at least be less wasteful and send some money back into repairing ecosystems.” If folks here see that as insufficient or misdirected, I’d genuinely rather hear the critique than pretend it solves the underlying structural issues you’re describing.

u/Banned_Altman • -6 points • 2025-11-28 01:59 UTC

While the author of the anti-AI post worries about slightly higher water bills and localized noise, the industrial meat complex is actively creating global, cascading crises that affect billions of people.

The Systemic Human Costs Ignored by Selective Empathy

The author critiques the impact of data centers as a failure of social empathy. To apply a consistent ethical standard, we must analyze the direct toxic burden and public health risks that the meat industry imposes on humanity—costs that make the localized nuisances of data centers seem utterly negligible.

1. The Global Public Health Crisis: Antibiotic Resistance

The primary threat to modern medicine is antibiotic resistance, and factory farming is a well-documented driver.

* The Threat: Industrial farms routinely administer antibiotics to healthy livestock not to cure illness, but to promote unnatural growth in crowded, unsanitary conditions. The World Health Organization (WHO) and Centers for Disease Control (CDC) confirm that this massive, routine overuse creates antibiotic-resistant bacteria (“superbugs”) that jump from animals to humans through the food chain, air, and water.

* The Cost: This is not a localized noise problem; it is a global health emergency that threatens to render common human surgeries and treatments impossible. It is an existential risk far exceeding the scope of AI’s hardware footprint.

2. Environmental Racism and Community Poisoning (Ammonia & Liquid Waste)

The liquid waste and air pollution from Concentrated Animal Feeding Operations (CAFOs) do not disappear; they are systematically offloaded onto vulnerable communities.

* The Waste Stream: CAFOs generate colossal amounts of untreated fecal waste. This slurry is stored in vast, unlined manure lagoons which frequently leak into groundwater. The liquid is often sprayed onto nearby fields, creating a toxic aerosol fog that poisons the locals.

* The Poison: This process saturates the air and water of neighboring, often low-income communities, with deadly concentrations of pathogens, hydrogen sulfide, and ammonia. This leads to respiratory illnesses, neurological problems, and chronic community poisoning. This is a direct environmental injustice, contrasting sharply with the author’s focus on the inconvenience of data center energy use in frequently affluent areas.

3. World Hunger and Feed Conversion Inefficiency

The meat system actively exacerbates global food scarcity.

* The Efficiency Failure: Approximately one-third of the world’s agricultural output—the vast majority of crops like soy and corn—is fed directly to livestock. This is fundamentally inefficient: you must expend up to 10 calories of food energy (via crops) to produce 1 calorie of meat energy.

* The Human Cost: This process monopolizes land and feed that could be used to grow food for direct human consumption. By prioritizing the conversion of food into low-efficiency luxury products (meat) over feeding the 800 million people facing chronic hunger, the industrial meat system is a direct structural impediment to global food security.

4. Preemptive Argument: Nutritional Orthodoxy

When opponents pivot to a health-based appeal to fear, claiming vegan diets are nutritionally inadequate, it is essential to cite the scientific consensus.

* The Consensus: The world's leading organizations, such as the Academy of Nutrition and Dietetics (AND), confirm that "appropriately planned vegetarian, including vegan, diets are healthful, nutritionally adequate, and may provide health benefits."

* Life Stage Acceptance: Crucially, the AND confirms this is true for all stages of the life cycle, including pregnancy, lactation, infancy, childhood, adolescence, and for athletes. This consensus refutes the fear-mongering and establishes that the debate is purely ethical and environmental, not nutritional.

Op, you're vegan, right?

u/CuteCreatorgal • 2 points • 2025-11-28 02:05 UTC

Whataboutism.

This sub is specifically about Ai. Therefore my post is rooted in issues surrounding data centers.

u/aSkeptiKitty • 3 points • 2025-11-28 13:44 UTC

Oh not just whataboutism.

This isn't even the product of his own pondering in the issue. This is the product of AI and it shows.

Btw, it was not evoked here but AI has been associated with decreased cognitive abilities and a lack of critical thinking.

The copy/paste of the AI dump is a good demonstration of this. (I cannot decently call him the "author" as he did not write a single word of it).

u/Banned_Altman • -2 points • 2025-11-28 02:11 UTC

That is a structurally weak rebuttal. Dismissing a relevant ethical comparison as "Whataboutism" is a common debate tactic used to maintain a narrow frame, but "Whataboutism" is not a logical fallacy.

The issue is not what the sub is "specifically about," but the scale of the ethical failure which you introduced by claiming that "Pro AI" users struggle with empathy and operate from a "keep up or perish" mindset.

Your attempt to restrict the ethical discussion is a logical failure that serves only to protect your own consumption habits:

* The Scale of Empathy: When assessing empathy and resource allocation, the magnitude of the problem is the only relevant measure. We are comparing:

* AI's Localized Harm: Increased electricity costs and noise pollution near data centers.

* Meat's Systemic Harm: Global antibiotic resistance, global hunger, and direct chemical poisoning of low-income, often minority, communities via manure lagoons and spray irrigation.

* The Ethical Contradiction: You are claiming the moral high ground over a corporate utility fee while aggressively attempting to silence documentation that shows your consumption habits are linked to disadvantaged people breathing aerosolized fecal matter ("liquid shit") and suffering chronic health issues.

* The Purpose of the Dismissal: Your defense of "Whataboutism" confirms that your critique is not rooted in a universal ethical standard, but a convenient, selective one. You are deploying a bad debate tactic—feigning concern for resource ethics—as a shield to justify a system that causes exponentially more harm. You are attempting to claim moral superiority over a hypothetical problem while actively defending a system of documented, ongoing injustice. Your post is rooted not in specific data center issues, but in the desire to secure your right to a cheeseburger without ethical accountability.

u/CuteCreatorgal • 1 points • 2025-11-28 04:30 UTC

Tiny peepee energy 🍌

u/No-Teacher-6713 • 2 points • 2025-11-28 02:32 UTC

This **entire** exchange of **AI-generated** **messages**—from the **initial** post to this **reply**—has consumed an **estimated** **half** **liter** of fresh water for cooling the **data center servers**—. 💧 🌊 🔥 🌍 🗑️ 🤖

u/LongPenStroke • 3 points • 2025-11-28 09:11 UTC

And what about the coal burned that is polluting the air we breathe and the water used to cool those coal burning plants.

The fact is, most of these data centers are being built and used on non renewable energy grids. They aren't using solar, nor are they using wind, as it would drive up the price even more.

It's funny how AI Bros focus on the water used only on their CPU and forget all the rest.

u/Banned_Altman • -3 points • 2025-11-28 02:43 UTC

Nah, this old data, im pretty sure gemini is down to less than one ml per prompt.

[https://preview.redd.it/9u8fkig7vw3g1.png?](https://preview.redd.it/9u8fkig7vw3g1.png?width=1080&format=png&auto=webp&s=319ee2f6da0b6b54bde005c860754b515f0b682c)

[width=1080&format=png&auto=webp&s=319ee2f6da0b6b54bde005c860754b515f0b682c](https://preview.redd.it/9u8fkig7vw3g1.png?width=1080&format=png&auto=webp&s=319ee2f6da0b6b54bde005c860754b515f0b682c)

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2025-11-29 08:59 UTC

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